
KEN ST. CLAIR

PITCHING YOUR STARTUP

Narrative · Deck · Access

THREE PROBLEMS. ONE PITCH.

| PITCHING IS THREE PROBLEMS

NARRATIVE

What's the story?
What's the arc? Why
should anyone care?

DECK

The artifact you build to
carry the narrative.
Slide-by-slide.

ACCESS

How you get that
narrative + deck in
front of the people who
matter.

Work them in that order. First the story, then the artifact, then how you get it in the room.

PART 1: THE NARRATIVE

A PITCH IS NOT A BRIEFING.

 Summary  Feature list  Product explainer

Pitches are narratives that inspire people to action.

| A FRAMEWORK FOR NARRATIVES

ANDY RASKIN'S STRATEGIC NARRATIVE

Five elements. Used by Zuora, Drift, Salesforce, and hundreds of others. Battle-tested on the world's hardest audiences.

→ ["The Greatest Sales Deck I've Ever Seen"](#)

We'll walk through all five. Then we'll look at how to *open*, because the opening is where most first-time founders get it wrong.

| RASKIN'S FIVE ELEMENTS

1 Name a big change in the world your problem, reframed as a shift

2 Show there'll be winners and losers stakes

3 Tease the promised land desirable, hard to reach alone

4 Features as magic gifts each one overcomes an obstacle

5 Present evidence customer stories, metrics, demos

RASKIN ELEMENT 1: CHANGE IN THE WORLD

Raskin is about how you *open* with your problem: package it so the investor leans in instead of leaning out.

STATIC PROBLEM STATEMENT

"Hospitals lose medical equipment all the time."

SAME PROBLEM, REFRAMED AS CHANGE

"Hospital M&A has tripled in three years. Inventory systems weren't built for that."

The problem hasn't changed. The opening move has.

| RASKIN ELEMENT 2: STAKES

Once you've named the change, make the consequences real.

"Companies that move fast will capture this market. Companies that don't will be consolidated or displaced within 5 years."

The investor should be thinking: *which side of this do I want to be on?*

RASKIN ELEMENT 3: THE PROMISED LAND

Before you show your solution, show the desired future state.



Raskin's rule: the promised land must be *desirable and difficult for the prospect to reach without outside help*.

If the audience can imagine getting there on their own, you haven't described a compelling enough promised land.

RASKIN ELEMENT 4: FEATURES AS MAGIC GIFTS

Don't list features. Frame each one as a gift that overcomes a specific obstacle between here and the promised land.

FEATURE LIST

"AI-powered matching. Real-time alerts.
Dashboard analytics."

GIFT FRAMING

"Find who your team already trusts. No
more cold applicants with fake LinkedIns."

This is essentially the same as saying focus on use cases, but it reminds you to weave a story and be eloquent about it.

| RASKIN ELEMENT 5: EVIDENCE

You've promised a land. Now prove people can get there. Match your evidence to your claim.

People want this

Signups, waitlist, letters of intent

People use this

DAU/MAU ratio, session frequency, retention at day 7/30

People love this

A specific quote from a named person with context

It works

Case study or white paper: named customer, baseline, outcome

The market is real

Named paying customer or signed pilot

You're growing

Week-over-week or month-over-month slope, not

| FROM NARRATIVE TO DECK

Your narrative is the argument. Your deck is the artifact that carries it.

NARRATIVE

The story arc: why now, who's affected, what changes, why you. Lives in your head and your script.

DECK

The visual sequence that carries the narrative. Slide by slide. The story tells you which slides you need and in what order.

Don't build the deck first. Build the narrative first, then let it dictate the structure.

PART 2: THE DECK

SEVEN SLIDES EVERY TEMPLATE AGREES ON

1 Problem

2 Solution

3 Market

4 Business Model

5 Competition

6 Team

7 The Ask

SLIDE-BY-SLIDE: WHAT GOES ON EACH

| COVER / TITLE

Job: Give the investor a mental model in 2 seconds.

INCLUDE

- › Company name
- › One tagline: what you do, for whom
- › "The X for Y" framing

CUT

- › Taglines like "the future of X"
- › Buzzword bingo
- › Your logo at 500px

This is an opportunity to create an instant mental model. Don't miss it.

| SLIDE 1: PROBLEM

Job: Make the investor feel the pain. A great problem slide makes them nod; they recognize the reality you're describing. This is where you prove you've talked to real people.

INCLUDE

- › A specific pain, for a specific person, in a specific context
- › Why current solutions *fall short*, not that they don't exist

CUT

- › Abstract market conditions
- › Your company name (this slide is about the customer)
- › "Consumers demand better experiences" (everyone does)

| WHY NOW

The most skipped slide. Also the most powerful when done well.

THREE TO FIVE TIMESTAMPED EXTERNAL CONDITIONS

- › A declining cost curve
- › A regulatory change
- › A behavior shift
- › A new enabling technology
- › A consumer psychology shift

Sequoia's sharp version: "Nature hates a vacuum. Why hasn't your solution been built before now?"

I "BECAUSE AI" IS NOT A WHY NOW

Vague AI reasoning is the 2026 version of "because the cloud."

VAGUE

"AI is transforming everything and we're riding that wave."

SPECIFIC

"The cost of a single LLM inference dropped 85% in 18 months. A workflow that was \$40 per user/month is now \$2. Our business model didn't exist two years ago."

| SLIDE 2: SOLUTION

Job: Connect your mechanism directly to slide 1's pain. The investor should be able to draw a line from the problem you described to exactly what your product does about it. Investors spend about 33 seconds here. Clarity beats completeness.

INCLUDE

- › What your product actually *does*
- › The core mechanism
- › Why it's **better**, not just different

CUT

- › Feature lists ("Intuitive. Powerful. Scalable.")
- › Technical architecture diagrams
- › Product roadmap

| SLIDE 3: MARKET

Job: Convince the investor the opportunity is big enough. Use *both* approaches: top-down for credibility and research context, bottom-up to show you've thought through the business model.

TOP-DOWN

"The global recruiting market is \$215 billion."

Establishes credibility. Shows you know the space. Gives investors a familiar frame of reference.

BOTTOM-UP

"31,000 mid-size US companies × 12 reqs × \$2,400/req/year = \$890M addressable."

Shows business model thinking. Every number is defensible. Proves the math works.

Lead with top-down for scale, then ground it with bottom-up math.

| PRODUCT

Job: Prove the thing exists and works. This is the "show don't tell" moment. One well-chosen screenshot should make your UX legible in 3 seconds; the investor should immediately see what the user sees and understand why it's valuable.

KEEP

- › One hero screen showing the core action
- › One sentence of caption
- › Annotations if the value isn't visually obvious

CUT

- › A full product tour or six screenshots
- › Marketing copy ("Intuitive. Powerful.")
- › Anything requiring more than a 3-second glance

| SLIDE 4: BUSINESS MODEL

Job: Prove the economics work. Investors need to understand the payment structure and unit economics before they can evaluate the investment: not just who uses the product, but who pays, what they pay for, and whether the margins are viable. DocSend data: investors spend **94% more time** on the Business Model slide in decks they go on to fund versus decks they pass on, even though the slide itself ranks 6th in absolute time. Investors who are seriously interested stress-test the economics harder.

ANSWER THESE

- › Who **pays** (not who uses)?
- › What do they pay for, and how often?
- › Rough unit economics: LTV, CAC, payback period

CUT

- › 5-year revenue projections (save those for Financials)
- › Vague pricing ("TBD" or "enterprise pricing")
- › "We'll figure out monetization at scale"

| TRACTION

IF YOU HAVE REVENUE

- › MRR / ARR
- › Growth rate MoM
- › Customer count
- › Retention

IF YOU'RE PRE-REVENUE

- › Active users, engagement
- › Waitlist depth
- › Signed pilots, LOIs
- › Notable partnerships



Show the slope, not the point. \$50K MRR growing 25% MoM beats flat \$500K MRR.

| SLIDE 5: COMPETITION

Job: Show you've mapped the landscape honestly and you have a defensible wedge. Investors see hundreds of decks and focus on specific industries; they know your competitors. Acknowledging them shows market sophistication; ignoring them signals naivety.

INCLUDE

- › Direct competitors
- › Indirect alternatives
- › **The status quo** (Excel, email, doing nothing)
- › Why you're different *and* defensible

CUT

- › "No competition" (always wrong)
- › The 2×2 where you're alone in the upper-right
- › Dismissing incumbents without explaining their constraints

"NO COMPETITION" IS NEVER THE RIGHT ANSWER

WHAT YOU MEAN

"No one is doing exactly what we're doing."

WHAT AN INVESTOR HEARS

- › "They don't understand their market"
- › "They haven't talked to customers"
- › "Either this isn't real or it's not defensible"



Hunter Walk's test: what would your competitors say about this slide? If you can't defend the axes, leave it out

| SLIDE 6: TEAM

Job: Answer "why these people, for this problem?" Investors are often backing the team as much as the idea. The single most important signal is specific domain experience that makes you uniquely positioned to solve this, not that you're smart or passionate.

INCLUDE

- › Founders + key leadership
- › Photos, short titles
- › **"Why this person, for this problem"**
- › Specific domain experience that matters here

CUT

- › Generic "passionate / experienced / driven"
- › Advisors standing in for founders
- › Companies you briefly worked at but didn't do the thing

| SLIDE 7: THE ASK

Job: Make it easy for an interested investor to say yes. Be specific about what you need, how you'll deploy it, and what milestones it buys. Vagueness signals you haven't thought through the raise.

ANSWER THESE

- › How much are you raising?
- › At what stage (pre-seed, seed)?
- › How will the capital deploy?
(product, sales, hiring)
- › What milestones does this enable?
- › How much runway does it buy?

CUT

- › Vague "we're looking for strategic partners"
- › No number at all
- › A use-of-funds pie chart with no milestones attached

LIVE PITCH ≠ SENT DECK

| TWO ARTIFACTS, NOT ONE

The "universal deck fallacy" is the #1 first-time-founder mistake. The deck you pitch from is not the deck you send.

	Live pitch deck	Sent / leave-behind deck
Slides	10–12	15–20
Text per slide	Near-zero; readable in 3 seconds	Full sentences; headlines state conclusions
Function	Reinforces your voice	Stands alone as a visual white paper
Core risk	Slides compete with your voice	Too sparse to survive without you

| THE FOLLOW-UP MISTAKE

WHAT MOST FOUNDERS SEND

The same minimal live deck: big images, one-word slides, no context. Partners who weren't in the room can't evaluate it.

WHAT YOU SHOULD SEND

The reading deck: full sentences, headlines that state conclusions, stands alone without your voice.

 **Rule:** always send the *reading* deck as follow-up. Two artifacts, not one.

| WHERE THE TEMPLATES DISAGREE



WHY NOW

Only Sequoia dedicates a slide. Everyone else folds it in. First-time founders consistently skip it.



TEAM PLACEMENT

Conventional templates put Team at slide 6 or beyond. Thiel and NFX put it at 2–3. The data says earlier.



SLIDE COUNT

Kawasaki: 10. NFX: ~15. The DocSend data: 15–20 beats very short or very long decks.

| BREAKING THE 10-SLIDE RULE IS FINE

LINKEDIN

38

slides + appendix
(sophisticated leave-
behind)

YOUTUBE

10

slides
(Sequoia already knew
them)

BUFFER

13

slides
(right for a traction story)

The rule is a heuristic. The story dictates the count.

WHAT INVESTORS ACTUALLY DO WITH YOUR DECK

| DOCSEND'S 2024 DATA

3:44

AVERAGE TIME ON A FUNDED DECK

2:31

COLD DECK READ TIME

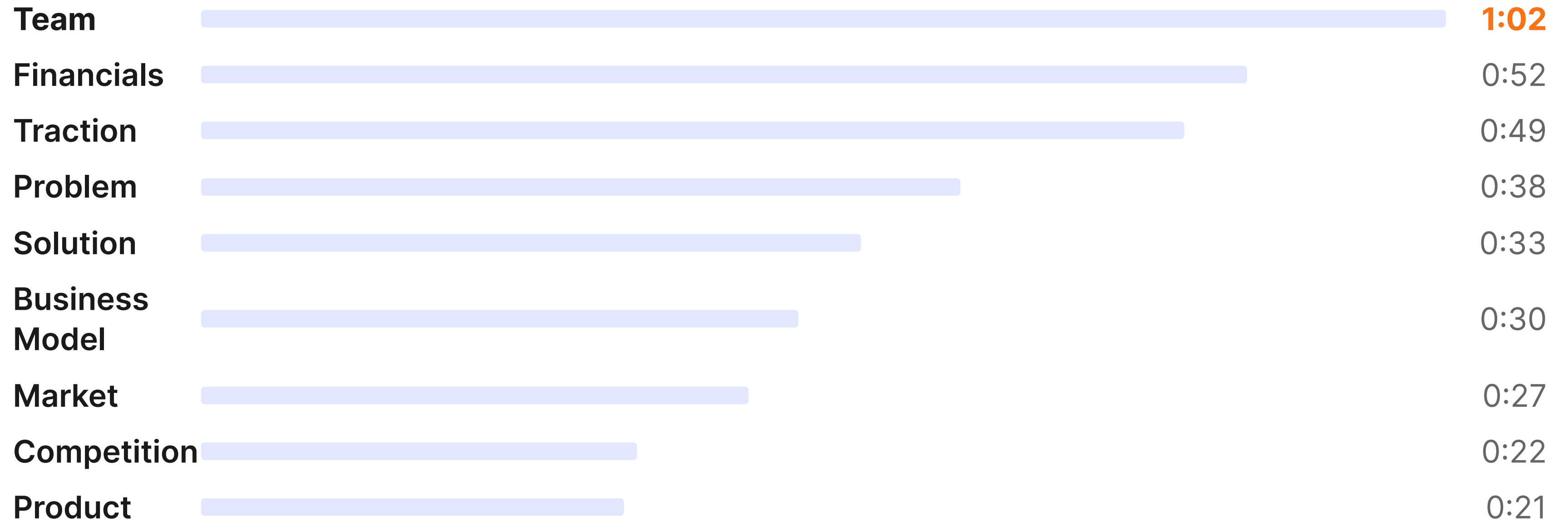
4:18

WARM DECK READ TIME

Funded decks get ~4 minutes of attention on first read. That's a *skim*. Every slide needs to earn its place.

Source: [DocSend 2024 Startup Fundraising Report, summary via PitchGrade](#)

| PER-SLIDE ATTENTION (FUNDED DECKS)



Slide 6 (Team) gets **3x the attention** of the product slide.

TEAM GETS THE MOST INVESTOR ATTENTION

1:02

TEAM SLIDE

0:21

PRODUCT SLIDE

0:38

PROBLEM SLIDE



Most templates put Team at slide 6 or later. If your team is the strongest reason to back you, consider moving it to position 2 or 3.

| SLIDE COUNT REALITY

Guy Kawasaki wrote "10 slides" in 2005, for a projector in a conference room.

Today's decks are read async on laptops. Research from DocSend and Harvard: decks in the **11–20 slide range outperform** decks that are too short or too long.



Aim for 10–12 slides in the live deck, 15–20 in the leave-behind.

WHAT THE FAMOUS DECKS TEACH

| CANONICAL DECKS: CLICK TO OPEN

LinkedIn Series B

Reid Hoffman's annotated deck, reidhoffman.org

Airbnb 2009 Seed

12 slides. The most studied seed deck in history.

Front Series A

Mathilde Collin published it herself with annotations, [Medium](https://medium.com/)

Dropbox: Startup Lessons Learned

Drew Houston on how Dropbox grew, [SlideShare](https://slideshare.net/)

| LEAD WITH THE HARDEST OBJECTION

The best decks identify the single hardest question about their business and address it *early*.

- › **LinkedIn (Series B):** "How will LinkedIn make money?" → slide 2
- › **Buffer (seed):** led with paying customers before anything else
- › **Facebook (2004):** led with 65% daily unique user rate

Each founder identified the #1 objection *for their specific business* and structured around it.

PART 3: ACCESS

YOUR NARRATIVE AND DECK DON'T | MATTER IF NO ONE SEES THEM

THE ACCESS PROBLEM

Warm introductions convert to meetings at 40–50%. Cold emails convert at 1–5%. The deck almost never earns the meeting on its own. The relationship earns the meeting; the deck survives it.

| THE ACCESS MATH

40–50%

WARM INTROS → FIRST MEETING

1–5%

COLD EMAILS → FIRST MEETING

Your deck almost never earns the meeting on its own. The **relationship** earns the meeting; the **deck** survives it.

Source: [DocSend 2024 Startup Fundraising Report, via PitchGrade](#). These are rough consensus figures across practitioner sources; individual results vary by stage, market, and quality of outreach.

| MAP YOUR INTRO GRAPH

Before you start pitching for real, sit down with a spreadsheet and list:

- 1 Every person you know who **knows investors**
- 2 Every **alum from your school** working at a VC firm
- 3 Every **founder you could reach** whose company was backed by a VC on your target list
- 4 Every **customer** of yours who knows an investor

This is tedious, which is exactly why most first-time founders skip it, and why doing it is an advantage.

THE FIRST CHECK IS HALF THE WORK.

"Getting the first substantial offer can be half the total difficulty of fundraising."

Paul Graham, How to Raise Money

TREAT EVERY "MAYBE" AS A NO UNTIL A SAFE IS SIGNED

All of these are functionally passes:

- › "We love what you're building"
- › "Let's keep talking"
- › "Can you send me your deck?" (after they've already seen it)
- › "Circle back when you have a lead"
- › "I have a lot going on"

| COMMUNITY-SPECIFIC ACCESS

- › **Your accelerator or startup lab:** residency gives direct investor access; use it during the program, not just at demo day
- › **Alumni angel networks:** people who've made money and want to back the next generation; searchable on LinkedIn
- › **Venture competitions:** non-dilutive prize capital, plus visibility to judges who actively invest
- › **Student-run funds:** Dorm Room Fund (First Round), Contrary, and similar funds operate at major universities and move fast
- › **Local seed ecosystem:** every major city has 5–10 seed funds that specifically source from nearby communities

WHAT A REAL WARM INTRO LOOKS LIKE

Not all introductions are equal. The value depends on who the introducer is and how well they know the investor.

- 1 A founder the investor has already backed** highest signal; same-week meeting
- 2 An angel already in your cap table** co-investor vouching for you
- 3 A mutual professional contact** moderate; depends on how well the contact is known
- 4 An intro the investor didn't request** only marginally better than cold

ANGELS VS. SEED FUNDS: PITCH DIFFERENTLY

ANGEL INVESTORS

- › Decide in 1–2 meetings; can wire in days
- › Betting on the **founder** more than the model
- › Check size: \$10K–\$100K typically
- › Want the story and credibility; less scrutiny on unit economics
- › Best ask: specific amount, no

SEED FUNDS

- › 4–6 week process; partner meeting required
- › Betting on **traction** and path to Series A
- › Check size: \$250K–\$1M+
- › Will scrutinize unit economics, CAC, retention
- › Best ask: clear use of funds + 24-

| COLD EMAIL: WHAT ACTUALLY WORKS

Cold email is a last resort, not a strategy. But when you have no warm path, here is what raises the odds:

WHAT WORKS

- › Lead with a specific metric or traction signal
- › One sentence on why *this investor*: cite their portfolio or writing
- › Under 150 words total
- › No deck attached: attach nothing
- › Subject line: specific and low-

WHAT KILLS RESPONSE

- › "We're disrupting the \$X billion market..."
- › No evidence you researched the firm
- › Deck attached to the first email
- › Long paragraphs explaining the business

| ACCESS, TL;DR

1 Warm intros, not cold email, get meetings

2 Build your **intro graph** before you need it

3 Run investors **in parallel**, not serial

4 The **first check** unlocks the rest

5 "**Maybe**" is no until the SAFE is signed

GO BUILD SOMETHING
WORTH PITCHING.

Ken St. Clair